

Promotional Examination 2025 Paper 2 Answer Scheme

To note:

- **Bolded words** must be paraphrased
- Underlined words must be captured, need not be paraphrased.

1. What is the author's purpose in using the phrase 'Let's face it' (line 7)? [2m]

From Passage		Suggested Answer	Marks
Let's face it, success rarely lands in our laps like a <u>ripe apple</u> . (lines 7-8)	A	[FUNCTION] To get the reader to <u>come to terms with/acknowledge</u> that... OR To <u>emphasise the unpleasant truth/ignored reality</u> that... Note: Do not accept 'emphasise' on its own	1m
	B	[CONTEXT] [INF] success does not come <u>naturally/ automatically/ without effort</u>. OR One <u>needs to work</u> for success Note: inference must be captured.	1m

2. According to the author, in what ways are our greatest achievements 'built on a foundation of relentless effort' (line 9)? [2m]

From Passage	Pt.	Suggested Answer	Marks
putting in the " blood, sweat, and tears ," (lines 9-10) / the Wright Brothers toiling away in their workshop... Or picture Marie Curie, hunched over lab benches long after the rest of Paris had gone to sleep (lines 11-13)	A	[INF] When people give their utmost/extreme/unstinting effort / when people work very hard Note: the extent/degree of effort needs to be captured	1m
the willingness to go the extra mile . (line 10)	B	and do more than is expected/ necessary. Do not accept: Working harder than others.	1m

3. In paragraph 3, how does the author illustrate the 'passion' (line 17) experienced by those in different occupations? [3m]

From Passage	Pt.	Suggested Answer	Marks
It's the artist who <u>can't resist losing</u> themselves in a world of colours (line 18)	A	<i>The author gives examples how ...</i> The artist who <u>cannot help</u> himself being immersed in colours.	1m
the entrepreneur who wakes up with a <u>million concepts</u> swirling in their head (line 19)	B	[FOCUS: Volume of ideas] The entrepreneur who has <u>many ideas</u> / insights .	1m
the coder who finds poetry in the logic of <u>algorithms</u> . (lines 19-20)	C	The coder who is inspired by the beauty/ art in <u>algorithms</u>	1m

4. According to the author, what are the qualities of an 'effective support system' (line 24)? [2m]

From Passage	Pt.	Suggested Answer	Marks
Surround yourself with people who <u>share</u> your vision (line 25),	A	Be with people have the <u>same goals/ aspirations</u> as you. Do not accept: views/perspectives/outlook/like-minded people	1m: 1-2 points 2 m: 3+points
Keep close to those who believe in you even when <u>you doubt yourself</u> .	B	Be close to those who have faith in you when you are <u>uncertain of yourself</u>	
They're the ones who pick you up when you <u>stumble</u> (line 28)	C	Who assist/help/encourage/motivate you when you <u>fail</u>	
celebrate your <u>victories</u> with <u>unrestrained joy</u> . (line 28)	D	And be <u>very/genuinely happy</u> for you when you <u>succeed</u> .	

5. In paragraph 5, what is **one** distinction does the author draw between societal and personal definitions of success? [2]

From Passage	Pt.	Suggested Answer	Marks
let's not get caught up in the societal definition of success. Success isn't a one-size-fits-all proposition (lines 29-30)	A1	[FOCUS: Success determined for you vs you deciding] [INF] A1: Societal success is seen as something that is determined/ prescribed for you	2m or 0
Define success on your own terms, what truly sets your soul on fire. (line 32)	B1	[INF] B1: <u>whereas</u> personal success is driven by your own motivations/passion	

OR

From Passage	Pt.	Suggested Answer	Marks
let's not get caught up in the societal definition of success. Success isn't a <u>one-size-fits-all</u> proposition (lines 29-30)	A2	[FOCUS: Limited idea of success vs varied ideas of success] [INF] Success is seen as <u>standard/similar</u> for everyone	2m or 0
Is it building a thriving business, writing the next great American novel, or simple finding job that allows you to live a life you love?	B2	[INF] <u>whereas</u> there are <u>varied</u> options available	

From Passage 2

6. Summarise the author's reasons why people do not slow down to reflect and why they should do so.

Write your summary in no more than 120 words.

From the passage	Point	Paraphrased
(People do not slow down to reflect due to) a culture of achievement they are engulfed in (lines 7).	A	[Engulfed by a culture of achievement] They are entrenched in a culture of success
<u>constantly chase measurable outcomes</u> , be it grades or portfolio enhancements (lines 8-9).	B	[Constantly chasing outcomes] <u>Always pursuing tangible achievements</u>
pausing to reflect feels like stagnant inactivity which does not seem to contribute directly to any measurable progress (lines 10-11).	C	[Seen as not unproductive] Comes across as unproductive/unconstructive .
(They should slow down to reflect) ...to <u>learn</u> more about <u>ourselves</u> so that we can grow personally (lines 12-13)	D	[Personal growth and awareness] Reflection helps us <u>develop ourselves/self-awareness</u>
and <u>develop emotional</u> maturity (lines 13-14). OR understand how our moods can <u>influence our perceptions and decisions</u> ...reduce the feeling that we are being <u>swept away by events or emotions</u> . (lines 14-16)	E	[Emotional maturity/regulation] [INF] and <u>nurtures emotional</u> intelligence / regulation
turn <u>failures</u> into valuable <u>learning opportunities</u> (lines 17-18).	F	[Failure leading to learning opportunities] Transform <u>setbacks</u> into meaningful <u>lessons</u>
...I was able to <u>assess</u> and <u>identify</u> aspects where the incident was <u>beyond my control</u> (lines 20-21).	G	[Determining one's locus of control] Aids in <u>spotting</u> and <u>evaluating</u> areas that are <u>out of our hands</u> Note: Students can capture either 'assess' or 'identify'
<u>Play out ways</u> I could have handled the situation <u>differently</u> (lines 21-22),	H	[Imagine alternative scenarios] <u>Imagine/think of alternative scenarios</u> for managing the incident.
Identify what I needed to <u>better prepare</u> should <u>similar situations</u> occur (lines 22-23).	I	[Better prepared for similar situations] Know what is required to <u>be more ready</u> to face such <u>recurring scenarios</u>

We <u>gain insights</u> into our own positive abilities (lines 24-25).	J	[Discovering our strengths] We <u>discover</u> our strengths/ talents .
grow appreciative of the <u>people</u> and circumstances that helped <u>make those successes possible</u> (lines 25-26).	K	[More appreciative of people and circumstances] Become thankful/grateful for <u>those around us</u> and <u>situations</u> that <u>ensured</u> such achievements. NOTE: accept either 'people' or 'circumstances'
(When we avoid reflecting) ... <u>escape</u> from <u>processing</u> deeper <u>emotions</u> ... exacerbates <u>mental stress</u> , turning unaddressed thoughts into <u>psychological burdens</u> .	L	[Avoidance of emotions exacerbates mental stress] <u>Avoiding emotions</u> worsens/aggravates <u>mental worries</u> .
(Reflection allows us to be) <u>more intentional</u> in <u>what we pursue</u> (lines 32-33)	M	[More deliberate in our pursuits] We become <u>more</u> deliberate/purposeful in <u>our endeavours</u> .
<u>more</u> prepared for the <u>complexities</u> of life (line 33).	N	[More prepared for complexities] We are <u>better</u> equipped for life <u>challenges</u> .

14 points

No. of Points	1-2	3-4	5	6	7	8	9	10+
Marks	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8

Sample summary:

People do not reflect because they are entrenched in a culture of success ^[A], are always pursuing tangible achievements ^[B], and reflections seem unproductive ^[C]. However, people should reflect because it helps us gain great self-awareness ^[D], nurtures emotional intelligence ^[E], and transforms setbacks into meaningful lessons ^[F]. Furthermore, reflections help evaluate areas that are out of our hands ^[G] and allow us to image alternative scenarios for managing incidents ^[H], such that we know what is required to be more ready to face such recurring scenarios ^[I]. With reflections, we discover our strengths ^[J] and become thankful for factors that ensured such achievements ^[K]. This allows us to avoid emotions that worsen our mental worries ^[L] and become more purposeful in our endeavours ^[M], making us better equipped for life challenges ^[N]. (119 words)

7. Passage 1 states that hustling is “that feeling of being ‘in the flow’, where time dissolves and work feels exhilarating”. (lines 21 -22).

Identify **one** specific idea from Passage 3 which can be used to undermine this statement. Justify your answer. [2]

From Passage 3		Suggested Answer	Marks
		<i>The author in Passage 3 says that...</i>	
Elon Musk broke into tears describing to the New York Times how his 120-hour workweeks <u>damaged</u> his life and business, claiming how these were the “most <u>excruciating</u> years of my career”. (lines 7-9)	A	[EVIDENCE] [FOCUS: Elon Musk’s state of suffering] The author uses the example of Elon Musk who who had to work very long hours every week that was <u>detrimental</u> to his well-being / business.	1m
		This undermines the statement in Passage 1...	
	B	[JUSTIFICATION] Because the example demonstrates <u>how hustling was torturous</u> and did not result in happiness and satisfaction.	1m

8. Passage 2 states that in setting aside time to reflect, we give ourselves the room ‘to grow personally and develop emotional maturity’ (lines 13–14).

Identify **one** specific idea from Passage 3 which can be used to support this statement. Justify your answer. [2]

From Passage 3		Suggested Answer	Marks
		<i>The author in Passage 3 says that...</i>	
So instead, I <u>pause a lot more now to reflect</u> when projects come my way. I ask myself: “ <u>Is this worth my time? Is this what I want to do?</u> ” (lines 13-14)	A	[EVIDENCE: Reflecting for clarity] When he <u>stops to think</u> , it helped him make a <u>clearer</u> decision/understand his work.	1m
		This supports the statement in Passage 1...	
	B	[JUSTIFICATION: Why there is a chance for emotional maturity] Because it shows that when we reflect, we better <u>understand our motivations/purpose/ourselves</u> . Note: Focus is on what was learned when one pauses to reflect. Students can capture either ‘personal growth’ or ‘emotional maturity’.	1m

9. The reading passages cover a range of views about hustle culture.

How far do you agree that hustle culture offers more advantages than disadvantages?

Support your answer with reference to:

- the ideas and opinions from **at least** one of the reading passages
- examples drawn from your own experience and that of your society.

Passage/ Para	Author argues that	Possible areas of evaluation
Passage 1, Para 2	<u>Lines 7-9</u> 'The greatest achievements... are built on a foundation of relentless effort.' <u>Lines 9-11</u> 'It's about putting in the 'blood, sweat, and tears', as the saying goes, and the willingness to go the extra mile when others take a comfortable stroll.'	<i>The author of passage 1 argues that unceasing effort, doing more than is expected, are essential for making significant progress in life.</i> - Such a mentality is present in Singapore where there is a strong belief that goals can only be achieved with relentless effort and that hustling, going the extra mile is commendable and advantageous. Possible EV & examples as support - Increasingly common for youths to use their holidays and free time to sign on for multiple programmes or internships to build their portfolio while also juggling schoolwork. As reported by CNA, some start as young as secondary school. (https://www.channelnewsasia.com/singapore/internships-secondary-school-students-unpaid-5230706) - Working hours in Singapore are amongst the longest in the region with many Singaporeans feeling compelled to work long hours and to continuously upgrade to stay relevant in an "increasingly competitive" work environment, as they often warned. This acceptance and perhaps glorification of hustle culture is perhaps driven by persistent messaging conveyed by schools and government in past years. National Education messages will often convey how "No one owes Singapore a living" or how Singaporeans must constantly be productive, innovative, efficient and other similar adjectives to relevant and competitive. The Singapore post-independence story is often about the relentless effort and 'sacrifices' of the Merdaka and Pioneer generation that shaped modern Singapore. (https://www.straitstimes.com/singapore/merdeka-generation-accepted-hardships-made-sacrifices-pm) It conveys a badge of pride that to hustle, to keep on going the extra mile is hallmark of Singapore excellence and resilience. - This mentality and its advantages are also fuelled by how parents and youths believe that entry into many top organisations, scholarships, and schools require more than just excellent grades. This has lead to the pressure for students to pad their portfolio with multiple internships (as stated in the examples), to treat it as a norm to juggle various commitments such as VIA, CCA, job shadowing alongside their busy schedules. Social media posts may also add to this sense of insecurity if one only spends their holidays resting and not being 'productive'.

		<u>Balanced View</u> • However, the ill effects of hustle culture are being recognized and there have been efforts in Singapore to temper this message and to encourage less anxious busyness. • For example, MOE's new O-level scoring of L1R4 rationale was to give students more time to explore their strengths and interests or simply to have better 'study-life' balance. • Concerned with reports about burnouts and quiet quitting, corporations in Singapore are more focus on mental well-being, flexible working conditions, enforced leave to ensure workers have time to slow down and reflect. Whether this is possible or lip service is a point for consideration but it does show how the glorification of hustle culture is meeting some resistance in Singapore today.
Passage 2, Para 2	<u>Lines 7-9</u> 'a culture of achievement they are engulfed in, pressuring them to constantly chase measurable outcomes, be it grades or portfolio enhancements.'	<i>The author of passage 2 argues that we have created a negative 'culture of achievement' that subjects students to the mindless pursuit of quantifiable outcomes.</i> <u>Application to SG</u> • However, the success of Singapore comes with an extremely high cost of psychological burnout and increasing mental breakdowns, prevalent across many age groups and especially among Singaporean teenagers. Our stressful, fast-paced, competitive society has bred a toxic 'culture of achievement', where many are valued only by their 'measurable' achievements and not as persons in their own right. <u>Possible EV & examples as support</u> • Our youths today are suffering from severe mental burnout, evident in the escalating mental health cases and suicide rates in recent years. Many buckle under the unrelenting pressure of the high-stakes education system to perform and excel in their academic studies. In 2023, individuals under 29 years old accounted for nearly 30% of all suicides in Singapore. The main stressors include academic and achievement-related pressures, and anxieties about future jobs. • Business Times study on hustle culture showed Singapore workers reporting the lowest engagement and job satisfaction compared to neighbouring countries • This has also breed a sense of superiority and lack of empathy and growing demoralization among those perceived as 'inferior' or 'weaker' in society who are unable to keep up with the demands of schoolwork or working life. A stigmatization for those that are not willing to put in the long hours and relentlessly climb the corporate ladder. • The constant exposure to social media has also intensified such competition with greater awareness of the differences in social status, wealth and power among various social groups, perpetuating envy and an overall dissatisfaction of one's life. • Despite changes to the education system, such as altering the PSLE scoring system, the removal of key examinations at various levels, the greater focus on formative assessments, these have

		not eased the stress and tension on local students since the competition for certain high-paying jobs still exist. As such a 'culture of achievement' can never be eradicated and will continue to exert its toxic influence on young Singaporeans, leaving a legacy of mindless hustle that is detrimental to socio-emotional health of both the individual and society.
Passage 1, Para 3	<u>Lines 20-21</u> 'This passion fuels the hustle, transforming it from a mindless grind into a thrilling chase.' <u>Lines 21-22</u> 'It's that feeling of being 'in the flow', where time dissolves and work feels exhilarating.' <u>Line 31</u> 'Define success on your own terms and what truly sets your soul on fire.'	<i>The author of passage 1 argues that passion is what makes the hustle meaningful, turning it from something mundane to an exciting, all-consuming pursuit.</i> Application to SG - In recent years, there have been an increasing number of young Singaporeans who have veered off from the traditional pathways of success to pursue their passions. Many young workers, particularly Gen Z, want their careers to align with their personal values and provide a sense of contribution, not just financial stability. Possible EV & examples as support - The trend of 'side hustling' is on the rise among many Gen Z workers post-pandemic stemming from a desire for personal fulfilment and creative expression. With the national curriculum's increasing focus on creativity and innovation in the polytechnics and universities, this has encouraged young Singaporeans to try something new or different. - The increasing incidences of 'career imposters', a term that refers to pivoting to careers one is not formally trained for, among Gen Zs also reflect a desire to do work that brings meaning to them, trading predictability for purpose. A 2023 study by global workforce solutions company ManpowerGroup found that 97 per cent of Singapore respondents said having meaning at work was important to them. - In a society that over-values academic excellence and professional stability, aided by constant social media exposure, many young Singaporeans are starting to question the meaning of life in this intense rat race, and are finding ways to fulfill their 'personal mission' by doing work that sparks enthusiasm and joy. The recent pandemic has also made them rethink what is essential in life and to chase after more meaningful pursuits instead, to 'be in the flow' of what truly brings joy and contributing to society's well-being at the same time.
Passage 2, Para 3	<u>Lines 11-12</u> '...does not seem to contribute directly to any measurable progress. Yet, real growth requires time' <u>Lines 12-14</u>	<i>The author of passage 2 argues that we need to set aside time to introspective in the midst of our heady pursuits to develop ourselves and our emotional maturity, and to stay emotionally grounded in all situations.</i> Application to SG This idea is relevant to Singapore, where the culture of efficiency and the "hustle" mentality are deeply ingrained, but where reflection is increasingly recognised as essential for long-term development.

Passage 2, Para 4	‘When we set aside time to reflect, we give ourselves the space to learn more about ourselves so that we can grow personally and develop emotional maturity.’ <u>Lines 15-16</u> ‘reduce the feeling that we are being swept away by events or emotions.’ <u>Lines 17-18</u> turn failures into valuable learning opportunities.	Possible EV & examples as support - In the context of education, Singapore’s highly competitive schooling system has traditionally prized productivity, measurable outcomes, and constant achievement. Students often find themselves immersed in tuition, co-curricular activities, and leadership roles. However, recent initiatives, such as the Ministry of Education’s “Character and Citizenship Education” curriculum and the push towards reflective journaling in programmes like Values-in-Action (VIA) projects, show that deliberate pauses for reflection are seen as crucial for nurturing empathy and resilience, rather than just academic success. These practices not only mitigate stress but also develop emotional maturity, aligning directly with the author’s claim. The shift away from excessive streaming and the recent changes in assessment emphasise learning and reflection over raw grades, showing that the state deliberately prioritises self-awareness in its youth. - At the societal level, the government has recognised that a hyper-connected, high-pressure city-state risks emotional detachment. Singaporeans work some of the longest hours in the world, and with a culture that prizes pragmatism, many struggle to pause. In response, initiatives such as the National Care Hotline during Covid-19, the SG Mental Well-being Network, and the MindSG online portal were launched to provide avenues for reflection and emotional support. These are not merely safety nets; they actively promote personal growth. By encouraging Singaporeans to acknowledge vulnerabilities and seek help, they cultivate qualities like empathy, resilience, and humility. For instance, the surge in hotline calls during Covid reflected citizens’ willingness to reflect on their mental state rather than suppress it. This demonstrates maturity—moving from a culture of “just cope” to one where individuals learn to process emotions healthily. Furthermore, these initiatives push Singapore towards collective growth. Reflection is not only inward-looking but also relational. When employees and families use MindSG resources, they learn strategies for self-care and for supporting others. This strengthens social bonds and reduces stigma surrounding mental health. Over time, such practices foster a society where Singaporeans are not only productive workers but also emotionally intelligent citizens, capable of handling adversity and supporting one another. In this way, the government’s initiatives do more than manage stress; they embed reflection into daily life, guiding Singaporeans towards greater emotional maturity and being grounded — exactly what the author argues is essential for development.
Passage 1, Para 6	<u>Lines 36-37</u> ‘it’s a testament to the human spirit’s unwavering pursuit of dreams.’ <u>Lines 37-38</u>	<i>The author of passage 1 argues that the hustle turns our dreams into reality and helps us achieve unimaginable heights of excellence in our pursuits.</i> Application to SG Relevant to Singapore’s meritocratic culture, where “hard work pays off” is ingrained in the education and employment system.

	It's about taking the raw material of our desires and shaping them into something tangible, something remarkable <u>Lines 41-42</u> a powerful force that can take us from the land of <i>what ifs</i> to the summit of our own potential.	The national narrative emphasises perseverance and hustle as keys to upward mobility. • The ethos of “chiong” (pushing hard) is celebrated in schools, national service, and workplaces. Success stories of entrepreneurs, top scholars, and athletes reinforce the idea that tireless effort leads to breakthroughs. • Government policies (e.g. SkillsFuture, continuous reskilling initiatives) promote hustle as essential to remain competitive in a globalised economy. Possible EV & examples as support • Education: Students who work relentlessly in the highly competitive system often gain entry to prestigious programmes and scholarships, fulfilling aspirations of social mobility. For instance, graduates and scholars who overcame disadvantaged backgrounds often credit sheer effort and hustle. Even our current Minister of Defence, Mr Chan Chun Sing's humble upbringing and hard work in school and beyond are flouted as an example of how hustle can be highly rewarding and bring one to the top. • Sports: Joseph Schooling's Olympic gold in 2016 exemplifies hustle turning a dream into reality; years of rigorous training enabled him to achieve what seemed unimaginable for Singapore. • Business: (i) Grab co-founder Anthony Tan's relentless drive helped transform a small idea into Southeast Asia's leading superapp, showcasing hustle as a pathway to entrepreneurial excellence.; (ii) Rachel Lim (Love, Bonito) embodies the Singapore entrepreneurial spirit — started as a blogshop while juggling studies, faced early failures (even refunding all customers after a bad shipment), but persevered. • National resilience: Singapore's transformation “from third world to first” is often cited as proof of hustle at the societal level—relentless pursuit of excellence in governance, industry, and innovation.
Passage 2, Para 7	<u>Lines 27-28</u> 'In the absence of self-reflection, people bury themselves in work or digital distractions as an escape from processing deeper emotions.' <u>Lines 28-29</u> 'This avoidance exacerbates mental stress, turning unaddressed thoughts into	<i>The author of passage 2 argues that our avoidance of deep emotional processing via our preoccupations or obsessions worsens mental burnout. It is only through reflection that we learn to be more intentional in what we do.</i> Application to SG • Highly relevant to Singapore's “hustle culture” and emphasis on efficiency, where long working hours and obsession with productivity often prevent deeper emotional reflection. • Singaporeans may immerse themselves in work, school, or leisure distractions (gaming, social media) to avoid confronting stress, leading to burnout. • Yet national and institutional efforts (e.g. National Mental Health and Well-Being Strategy 2023, MOE's Character and Citizenship Education, MindSG portal) emphasise reflection, mindfulness, and intentional living as antidotes to burnout. Possible EV & examples as support

	psychological burdens.' <u>Lines 31-33</u> 'shift the focus away from merely doing more to becoming more—more intentional in what we pursue and more prepared for the complexities of life.'	• Singapore has one of the longest working weeks globally; cases of “quiet quitting” and rising youth burnout reflect avoidance of deep emotional processing. • The pandemic highlighted this: many coped with isolation and stress by bingeing entertainment or overworking, but the surge in calls to the National Care Hotline showed eventual recognition of the need for emotional reflection and help-seeking. • Workplace initiatives like mindfulness programmes (e.g. civil service’s push for mental wellness) reflect the value of reflection in creating sustainable productivity and intentional action. • Among students, heavy reliance on tuition, CCAs, and résumé-building can mask unprocessed stress. MOE’s move to reduce mid-year exams and shift towards holistic assessments reflects recognition that reflection and intentionality are crucial for long-term growth.
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